

Relationships Among People, Events & Ideas - Study Guide

Explain how one part of a text affects, develops, contrasts with, or reveals another.

Learning goal

Analyze how people, events, ideas, setting, and details interact - not just which ones appear next to each other.

A relationship needs a verb

When a question asks about a relationship, name what one element does to another. Useful verbs include causes, limits, motivates, contrasts with, reveals, strengthens, complicates, changes, prepares for, and explains.

Merely saying that two details are both in the passage is not enough. A strong answer describes the direction and effect of the connection. In literature, a setting may pressure a character into a choice. In informational text, one event may change how a program is designed.

Relationship	Useful question	Example
Person -> person	How does one person affect another?	A teammate's calm response makes the narrator reconsider leaving.
Event -> event	How does one event change what happens next?	A power outage forces the team to use a backup plan.
Setting -> action	How does context shape a choice?	A crowded platform makes the guide move the group indoors.
Detail -> idea	What role does this detail play?	A repeated failure example strengthens the argument for testing first.

Question language to recognize

- How does ____ affect ____ in the passage?
- What role does ____ play in the development of ____?

- How does the setting contribute to the character's decision?
- Why does the author include the detail about ____?

A reliable method

- 1 Name element A and element B.
- 2 Choose a precise relationship verb: causes, motivates, limits, contrasts, reveals, strengthens, or changes.
- 3 Find evidence showing the effect, not just the order.
- 4 Check direction. If A affects B, do not reverse the relationship unless the text supports both directions.

A useful sentence frame

A _____ B by _____. Example: "The unexpected crowd changes the plan by forcing the organizers to move check-in outside."

Worked example

Example

A student group planned to rehearse in the auditorium, but a pipe leak closed the room. Mei suggested using the covered courtyard instead. Because the courtyard had no projector, the group replaced projected slides with printed signs. During the presentation, several visitors said the signs were easier to read from a distance.

1. How does the auditorium closure affect the group's presentation?

- A. It causes the group to change location and replace slides with printed signs
- B. It proves the group never prepared
- C. It makes the visitors leave immediately
- D. It has no effect on the group's choices

Answer: A

The closure starts a chain of changes: new location -> no projector -> printed signs. The answer describes the effect, not merely the order.

Common traps

- Sequence without effect: A happens before B, but the option never explains how A matters to B.
- An unrelated connection that mentions both elements but does not describe their relationship.
- Reversed direction: the effect is presented as the cause.
- Unsupported symbolism or motive, especially in literary passages.

Quick check

Mini text

A community garden began locking its tool shed after several tools were misplaced. Volunteers could still borrow tools, but they now signed a checkout sheet and returned the key to a coordinator. Missing-tool reports fell during the next month.

1. How does the problem with missing tools affect the garden's procedure?

- A. It leads the garden to add a lock and checkout system
- B. It causes the garden to stop all volunteering
- C. It proves the shed is too small
- D. It has no effect

Answer: A. The earlier problem directly motivates the new procedure.